> Surat (Gujarat)- Great famine, highways unpassable, infested by thieves looking not for gold but grain; Kirka- Town empty. Half inhabitants fled. Another half dead; Dhaita- Children sold for 6 dams or given for free to any who could take them so they might be kept alive; Nandurbar (Maharashtra)-No space to pitch a tent, dead bodies everywhere. Noisome smell from a neighboring pit where 40 dead bodies were thrown. Survivors searching for grains in the excrement of men and animals. Highway stowed with dead bodies from Surat to Burhanpur.

He gives complete details about how the Tīmūrid lords were treating people. He wrote:

> In Bazar lay people dead and others breathing their last with the food almost near their mouths, yet dying for want of it, they not having wherewith to buy, nor the others so much pity to spare them any without money. There being no course taken in this Country to remedy this great evil, the rich and strong engrossing and taking perforce all to themselves.

There was no food for the general public while it was abundant for the Royal Tīmūrids. When the entire province was on its deathbed, Shah Jahan's war camp was in fair shape. It was spacious and plentifully stored with all provisions. The camp was receiving supplies from all the corners, far and near.[*]

Not only did Shah Jahan ensure that people felt the wrath of the 'famine' but the great Tīmūrid prince collected tax to build the tomb for Mumtaz. Tīmūrid Empire, established by Babur, was known for collecting the highest taxes in the world. The estimates tell us that they used to take a share of more than half of what the peasants produced.[†] In contrast, Hindu kings like that of the Vijayanagar Empire, charged one-sixth of the produce. This was almost four times less than the Tīmūrids.

I even came across Shah Jahan's revenue utilization. He invested a little more than one-third of the revenue in the sixty-eight princes and Amirs. One-fourth of the revenue went to his 587 officers. This implies that almost 62 per cent of the revenue was spent on merely 665 elites of the court.[‡]

After having read around the subject, it didn't take much time to conclude that Shah Jahan brought the famine over Gujarat, Malwa and Deccan by ravaging the cultivation completely. And then, the diverting of revenue to build the Taj Mahal coupled with the scarcity of rain caused the famine in which around eight million people died. This number is well attested in a letter written by a Dutch East India Company lawyer.[*]

I was startled. If Churchill can be held responsible for 'genocide' in Bengal, then Shah Jahan should also be held responsible for the genocide of around eight million people. Hence, the building which everyone has described as the pride of Bharat, was built at the cost of the blood of so many.